

The Impact *vs.* Risk Matrix. *Audit before you automate.*

95% of AI pilots never produce a return, and it is almost never the technology. It is because they started from the tool instead of the operation. This page is the diagnostic most people skip. Do it before you buy or build anything.

STEP 1 — MAP IT

Pick **ONE** process that steals your time every week and write it out step by step, the way it really works.

	PROCESS STEP (WHO DOES IT, WHAT HAPPENS)	IMPACT 1-5	RISK 1-5	DECISION
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				

Impact = how much it moves the needle if solved (time, errors, revenue, visibility). · **Risk** = what happens if the machine gets it wrong (customer, money, brand, trust).

STEP 2 — PLACE EACH STEP ON THE MATRIX

← LOW RISK HIGH RISK →

Low impact · High risk

Do not touch it yet. Not worth the risk.

High impact · High risk

Hybrid model: AI does the heavy lifting, a human reviews and approves.

Low impact · Low risk

Simplify it, eliminate it, or leave it manual. Automating a mess just speeds up the mess.

High impact · Low risk

Candidate for direct automation. Start here.

← LOW IMPACT HIGH IMPACT →

STEP 3 — THE DECISION RULE

- **High impact + low risk** → automate. This is your first project, not the flashiest one.
- **High impact + high risk** → hybrid. AI prepares, organizes, and recommends; the human decides. Never blind automation.
- **Low impact** → it does not need AI. Simplify it, eliminate it, or leave it manual.
- **Before you build, ask:** will my team trust this and use it? If people do not adopt it, there is no return, no matter how good the technology is.

Step 4 — Define the return **BEFORE** you build

How will you know it worked? Write one concrete, measurable signal (e.g. "get 5 hours a week back", "cut data-entry errors 30%", "respond to every lead in under 5 minutes").
